

Fifth Star Funds Screening Interview — Full Pitch Script

Anthony Ivy · Uncle May's Produce · ~8-minute pitch · For rehearsal, **NOT** for reading on camera

How to use this: read it aloud the night before. Cover the cheat-sheet talking points without staring at the script. On the day, work from the cheat sheet only.

Pace: ~1,150 words at 147 wpm = ~7:45. Leaves buffer under the 10-min cap. **Don't rush.** Fifth Star said they aren't scoring polish.

[0:00 — Open]

Hi, I'm Anthony Ivy, founder and CEO of Uncle May's Produce. Thanks for inviting me to the next round.

I want to use these minutes to walk you through four things: how we frame the problem, what I've actually built and shipped so far as a solo operator, what the early customer data is telling us, and the specific metrics your \$25K is sized to move.

[0:30 — How I Think About The Problem]

The problem we are solving is not grocery access. There are Whole Foods stores in Black communities. The problem is **cultural sourcing and Black economic circulation**.

Sixty-seven percent of Black shoppers visit three or more stores every month because no single store carries what they need. Forty percent say their store doesn't carry their cultural foods. Stores in Black neighborhoods stock fifty-two percent fewer produce varieties. And critically, **there is no system of record for what Black consumers actually buy**. Vendors can't measure their own demand. Investors can't find the Black food businesses that should be in their portfolios.

We are building that system. Retail is the acquisition engine. Vendors are the supply engine. The data layer is the moat.

[1:45 — What I've Actually Built]

Right now, it's me and the produce platform. I want to be clear about that. The flagship store has its own capital stack and its own team — SBA debt conditionally approved, GM signed, architect and store designer engaged. That's Chapter Two, and it isn't what we're talking about today.

What we're talking about today is what one founder has shipped, solo, into market:

A custom Next.js e-commerce platform — checkout, delivery routing, cart, Stripe integration, address autocomplete. No Shopify, no managed cart. We own the funnel down to the field level.

A live catalog of products sourced from Black farmers, launched April 30th.

Full observability — LogRocket session replays, Galileo AI classifying friction patterns every morning, GA4, Meta Pixel and CAPI, daily Stripe and Mailchimp reporting. A stack most pre-seed companies don't have. I built it without an agency.

And thirty-four paying customers in the first three weeks, average order value around ninety dollars.

[3:15 — What The Customers Are Telling Us]

I sat down with five paying customers in early May. The convergent signal is the one that matters: **"Black farmers" was the unprompted number-one purchase driver in four of five interviews.** It beat price. It beat speed. It beat variety.

Most venture investors expect price sensitivity in Black communities. Our data says the opposite. The willingness-to-pay driver is **economic circulation** — customers will pay to send their dollars to Black producers. That is the asset we are building the company around.

A second signal: the no-subscription choice. Customers read "no subscription required" as a trust signal, not a convenience. They've been burned by hidden auto-renew terms in CSAs.

And here is the honest gap we are also hearing: **we are out of the decision set for a full grocery basket today.** Our customers love what we stand for, but produce alone doesn't replace a grocery trip. They still go elsewhere for the rest of the cart. We know that. Closing it is the explicit purpose of the SKU expansion roadmap — the top-thirty additions are scoped from what these same customers told us they're going elsewhere to buy. We are buying our way into the basket, deliberately, with customer-validated SKUs.

[5:00 — The Metrics And The Honest Gap]

Here are the gate metrics I owe Fifth Star back:

- AOV between seventy-five and one hundred dollars
- Gross margin at or above thirty-five percent
- CAC at or below sixty dollars
- Repeat rate at or above twenty-five percent
- LTV-to-CAC at or above three-to-one

If we miss any of those gates, we do not open the flagship. Chapter Two is gated by Chapter One data, not by a calendar date.

Where we are today versus those gates: AOV is on track, around ninety dollars. Gross margin is in range. Repeat behavior is early but encouraging — Antoinette Woods is a three-time repeat in three weeks. LTV is unmeasured, and I marked it unmeasured in the application because the catalog was five days old when we wrote it. I will not invent a number I can't defend.

The metric that is broken, and that I want to name directly: **paid CAC is around two hundred dollars right now.** That is not capital-backable. It will not get this company to a Series A. We've paused paid spend, and we are working through the attribution stack and the conversion infrastructure to bring it down.

That is the specific number your twenty-five thousand dollars is sized to move.

[6:30 — How \$25K Gets Deployed]

The twenty-five thousand buys four things, in order, all aimed at moving CAC from two hundred toward sixty:

First, six months of disciplined Chicago paid acquisition testing. Small budget, tight cohort, measured weekly. Not a spray. A test.

Second, Black-farmer story creative. Our customer data says that message converts. Our current paid creative is generic. The cheapest way to test the right message is to put it on the screen.

Third, the top-thirty SKU expansion that pulls us into the customer's full basket decision set. Customers who can complete more of their cart with us repeat more and refer more. Both of those compress CAC.

Fourth, runway to validate the conversion infrastructure I've already shipped — ZIP UX, payment-element fixes, address autocomplete. The work is done. The twenty-five thousand buys the testing window to prove it.

That's how the dollars translate into the gate metrics. The ask is sized to the work.

[7:30 — Why Now]

Why now — the platform is live. The data is flowing. The customer signal is convergent and surprising in the right direction. The flagship has its own capital path on its own timeline. **Fifth Star's twenty-five thousand is the catalyst that lets Chapter One prove itself in market with the discipline a Fifth Star portfolio company should bring.**

Thank you. I'm looking forward to the questions.

[End — approximately 7:45]

Backup answers for the 4 focused questions

If asked: "What's the biggest non-obvious insight about your customer?"

Most venture investors expect price sensitivity in Black communities. Our customer data says the opposite. Across our five interviews, "Black farmers" was the unprompted number-one driver — it beat price, speed, and variety. The willingness-to-pay driver is economic circulation: customers want their dollars to land with Black producers. That is the asset we are building the company around.

If asked: "Tell me about a customer interaction that changed your thinking."

Morgan Dixon told me, unprompted, that she has been "hunting for food on the South Side" and named the 47th-and-Cottage-Grove gap by name. That is the same site the 4th Ward alderman raised with me in person last week. Our customers and the political infrastructure of the South Side are pointing at the same hole in the map. That was the moment I knew the demand thesis wasn't just my model — it's already in the street.

If asked: "What's the most resourceful thing you've done recently?"

Last week we retired every active promo code on the site so we could read the true organic conversion rate. A CRO consultant would have taken thirty days and ten thousand dollars to do the same analysis. I did it in twenty minutes by reading our own funnel. I let the funnel speak.

If asked: "If you got the \$25K tomorrow, what's the first \$5K you'd spend?"

Three to five short-form Black-farmer-story videos. Our customer data tells us the "Black farmers" message converts. Our current paid creative is generic. The fastest, cheapest test is to put the message on screen, run it against our existing Meta paid traffic, and measure whether conversion lifts. We'd know within ten days.